

DAY 16: REDUCE HEALTH INSURANCE COSTS

While I try to live a healthy lifestyle, I don't feel comfortable doing it without health insurance. We have medications to pay for, doctor visits a couple times a year, and the occasional hospital emergency for the "uh-oh's" we never expected. We've definitely experienced our fair share of medical hot messes to know that going without just isn't an option!

Of course, that doesn't mean I'm willing to accept the cost of our monthly premium as a permanent fixture in our budget. Every time open enrollment comes around, it reminds me to do my due diligence and call around for quotes, making sure that I have the best plan possible for the best possible price. But lately, it seems like great coverage is getting harder and harder to find.

In fact, I think most of us would agree that the health care system is pretty broken. Unless you have an awesome job with a large company, monthly premiums are one hefty expense without a lot of benefits to go with it. And for people like Joseph and me who are self-employed, it's even harder to get that protection of health insurance without the huge cost.

Thankfully, the industry is starting to shift, and although it's not perfect, I think we're definitely headed in the right direction. Pre-existing conditions are pretty much non-existent anymore, and everyone can experience at least one preventive care visit a year at no cost. Low-income individuals now have access to more affordable plans, and patients, in general, have a little more control over what and how much they pay. I can only hope the future provides us with better and even more options down the road!

But until that magical health care system finally arrives (one that everybody agrees with, that is), there are a few changes you can make to your insurance plan so it doesn't hurt as much every month. It takes a little bit of research on the front end, and lots of experimenting, but it can be done. Here are five recommended ways to get the care you need for less:

1. REASSESS YOUR CURRENT PLAN